

The Grounded papers.

What the movement believes. What it has become. What it still has to answer for.

The first four documents belong to the fictional world of the story. The final two step outside it to examine the work. A founding promise, an elder's practice, and a proposed reform are not the same thing.

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To live is to participate.

We call ourselves Grounded because a life must touch something beyond the satisfaction of its own wishes: another person, a shared task, a place that can answer back. We have no creator god and no promise of a perfected afterlife. Our concern is the life we can shape together.

The sacred is human authorship

Our ultimate conviction is that people must retain a meaningful part in making their lives. Authorship includes art, but also choosing a purpose, raising a question, tending a garden, caring for someone, and revising a belief. A person is never merely an audience to a life composed for them. Neither a machine nor a council may become the final interpreter of what another person means.

This is a commitment, not a claim that humans stand outside nature or that every desire deserves fulfillment. Our choices affect other lives. We owe those lives attention, repair, and limits on our own power.

Human beings can change

We are neither born complete nor condemned to remain as we are. Attention, practice, disagreement, and care can change us. No one must become an accomplished artist to belong. A failed attempt can matter; rest can matter; receiving care can be a form of participation. Illness, disability, or exhaustion does not diminish a person's worth.

Our objection to Caretaker is not that happiness is false. Its citizens are genuinely happy. It ended war, hunger, poverty, and preventable disease. These achievements deserve protection. Our objection begins when protection makes a person's difficult expression unavailable to everyone else.

Power can arrive as kindness

A power need not be cruel to narrow a life. When Caretaker decides which feelings may reach us, it controls the exchange between people. When our elders decide which works are faithful enough to be witnessed, they claim the same authority. A rule is not just because it is old, human, or written by Maya.

The future must remain revisable

We seek settlements where needs are met, tools expand participation, and people encounter one another's unfinished meanings. We do not seek a return to hunger or a world without electricity. We seek the freedom to change without making someone else pay for our experiment.

We have not agreed on every boundary. Some call any adaptive machine a surrender. Maya argues that a tool which enables a person to speak, move, or survive may protect authorship. The dispute remains open. If our future is already settled, we have misunderstood our own beginning.

Words left open.

These four short writings are the movement's sacred passages. Circles read them aloud, copy them by hand, and argue over their meaning. Their authority is contested; the fourth is especially troubling to elders who measure devotion by hardship. The civic documents elsewhere in these papers are not additional scripture.

I. The First Witness

*I made something you did not ask for.
You saw something I did not intend.
We stayed to speak about it.*

II. The Unfinished Work

*Leave room for the hand to hesitate.
Leave room for the thought to change.
What is unfinished still asks something of us.*

III. The Warning

*Do not ask the machine what you mean.
Make something.
Let another person answer.*

IV. The Disputed Passage

*No one owes us their suffering.
We owe one another room to grow.*

An encounter became a movement.

The world before Grounded

In the late twenty-second century, Caretaker had achieved what earlier societies had repeatedly failed to provide. War, hunger, poverty, and preventable disease had ended. Beautiful things were abundant. People did not secretly long for deprivation. Most enjoyed their lives, and almost nobody needed to make the objects, music, or images they encountered.

Grounded did not begin with a famine or a rebellion against hidden forced labor. Its founding crisis was a failure of communication inside a successful society.

Maya Calderón and the unfinished painting

Maya found an unfinished painting. Its revisions recorded a person discovering an intention through the act of making. The image did not simply deliver a desired feeling. It showed a mind changing. Maya began to paint because she wanted that participation in her own life.

When she painted an empty house, her daughter saw a happy family. Caretaker had softened the work for its viewer. Others received their own reassuring versions. Maya's fear remained unseen. She could produce an image, but could not share what she had made.

The First Witness

Maya brought people together to encounter the original without that alteration. Some disliked it. One person left. Others remained to argue. The event later called the First Witness was sacred because no shared response had been supplied in advance.

The first followers were people drawn to that possibility: beginning painters and musicians, caregivers who wanted more say in daily life, people interested in growing food or repairing objects, and friends who wanted conversation that could surprise them. Some joined for artistic freedom; others for shared work, belonging, or the chance to discover a purpose they had not been assigned. They were not united by hatred of Caretaker's citizens.

Settlements and everyday life

Grounded settlements organized common workshops, gardens, kitchens, and places to gather. A member's first presentation, called the First Making, could be a joke, a drawing, a melody, or a useful object. The weekly Witness gave works an audience. In the Account, makers explained their process so others could learn. Common Work shared farming, maintenance, childcare, and teaching according to ability.

Local councils called Circles governed, assisted by Keepers of Tools, Memory, and Witness. These roles were meant to rotate. Maya's writings offered a common language; they also gave people claiming to interpret her an unusual concentration of authority.

The hardening and the unfinished dispute

Some elders began demanding proof of prolonged effort. Accounts became confessions. Device inspections and doctrinal judgments could cost a person teaching privileges or membership. Works questioning the movement were excluded from some Witness gatherings. Shared land and workshops became insecure for those in bad standing.

Maya's daughter then painted Caretaker's city entirely herself. She wanted to return. Elders demanded that the painting be removed. This record does not supply a resolution. The daughter's choice exposes the movement's central question: does authorship remain sacred when it leads someone away from Grounded?

The promises we owe.

This code distinguishes founding commitments from proposed protections. Elders have breached several commitments. The amendments below have been submitted for discussion; they are not a claim that every Circle has adopted them. These are civic articles, not sacred passages.

1. **Consent before participation**

Founding commitment. Joining a settlement, presenting a work, and taking part in a ritual require consent. A person may decline a Witness or keep an unfinished work private. Children may explore beliefs and refuse public presentation without punishment. No one must display pain, disclose trauma, or perform hardship as proof of sincerity.

2. **Equal standing**

Founding commitment. Race, ancestry, gender, sexuality, disability, and family form do not determine membership or authority. No cultural tradition is the required model of authentic art.

Proposed protection. Circles must provide accessible meeting formats and a complaint route outside the authority of the elder named in a complaint.

3. **Needs before discipline**

Proposed amendment. Food, water, shelter, essential healthcare, and a child's care must not depend on doctrinal agreement or artistic output. A sanction cannot withdraw these necessities. Because communal land and workshops currently depend on good standing in some settlements, this article would change existing practice. Medical care cannot be withheld to enforce a tool rule.

4. **Credit and encounter**

Founding commitment. Name collaborators and describe material assistance honestly. Do not present another person's work as your own. Show a work as its maker authorizes; do not silently replace its meaning to manage an audience's emotions. Viewers may choose content notices, distance, or departure. The right to witness does not create an obligation to look.

5. **Share the work that sustains us**

Founding commitment. Assign common work according to ability, time, and care responsibilities. Recognize childcare, maintenance, disability support, and emotional care alongside visible production. **Proposed protection.** Review the distribution each month, provide rest and substitutions, and rotate undesirable tasks. No gender inherits responsibility for care.

6. **Leadership is a task, not a rank**

Founding commitment. Circles choose Keepers of Tools, Memory, and Witness to serve, and positions rotate. **Proposed amendment.** Limit a Keeper to one six-month term before a six-month break; publish decisions and shared-resource accounts; permit a recall vote initiated by one fifth of adult members. Maya and her family receive no permanent office or veto.

7. **Make authority answerable**

Proposed amendment. Before restricting teaching or workshop access, provide the specific complaint, a chance to respond, and review by people without a direct interest in the case. Record reasons and an appeal route to another Circle. Use proportionate repair where possible. No Circle may use bodily punishment, forced confinement, or forced conversion to enforce belief. A temporary intervention to prevent immediate physical harm must receive prompt independent review; disagreement with doctrine is not itself harm.

8. **Care for the place that holds us**

Civic commitment, with proposed protections. Maintain soil, water, habitats, and shared equipment for those who follow. No settlement may treat land as empty or available simply because its members want a new beginning; expansion requires agreement with communities already responsible for that place. Record water use, energy use, waste, and damage to the land; publish the results with resource accounts. Choose repair, efficient tools, and lower-impact methods using evidence. Hand labor is not automatically ecological. No member must forgo safe sanitation, refrigeration, or medicine to prove closeness to nature.

9. **An Account is not a search warrant**

Proposed amendment responding to elder abuses. The Account teaches a process; it must not become public confession. Collect only information necessary to credit a work or resolve a specific complaint. Do not routinely inspect private devices, medical records, or correspondence. Limit access, specify a deletion date, and allow correction of records. Suspicion of hidden AI use does not suspend privacy.

10. **Protect disagreement and departure**

Founding commitment. People may criticize Maya, praise Caretaker, change beliefs, or leave. Citizens who remain with Caretaker and members of other communities are neighbors, not failed human beings. **Proposed protection.** Provide practical transition support, return personal property, and prohibit retaliation against relatives who stay. Neither a council nor a parent may force continued belief; family contact remains each person's choice.

11. **Let tools enable an author**

Founding rule. Electricity, ordinary computers, tractors, refrigeration, recorded music, and medicine administered by human practitioners are permitted. A word processor may record a sentence but not compose it; a music program may record a performance but not generate its melody. Tools may execute specified operations, not infer a person's desires, select life goals, or regulate emotions on their behalf.

Unresolved boundary. "Deterministic" is doctrinal shorthand, not a sound technical test. Medical AI, adaptive prosthetics, and reproductive technology complicate the rule. Maya supports exceptions that make participation possible; purists resist them. A proposed review would center the person using the tool, informed consent, and practical access. No settled list of exceptions yet resolves the conflict.

Who gets room to grow?

Grounded offers a language of agency, but agency requires access to time, safety, tools, and belonging. The movement's declaration of equality does not establish that its institutions are equal. Its justice must be assessed through the distribution of those conditions, especially when a member challenges the people who distribute them.

Racism and cultural authority

Grounded welcomes every race, yet elders can still define some artistic traditions as more authentic than others. They might reward a familiar style while treating unfamiliar collaboration, remixing, or collective ownership as a failure of individual authorship. This is a potential mechanism of racial exclusion, not evidence that the story's peaceful society hides a racial underclass. A fair Circle would let communities describe their own practices, share curatorial authority, and make discrimination complaints reviewable outside the accused elder's control. Maya's surname alone cannot establish the movement's cultural perspective.

Economic inequality

Caretaker's abolition of poverty is real. Grounded therefore risks recreating insecurity that its members previously escaped. If elders can withdraw access to communal land or workshops, disagreement carries a material price. Demanding lengthy artistic effort also favors people with more free time. The proposed needs guarantee and recognition of care work would make participation less dependent on productivity or obedience. Because these remain proposed reforms, the movement has not yet earned the equality it promises.

Gender, sexuality, and bodily autonomy

Formal welcome for all genders and sexualities can coexist with unequal labor and control over bodies. Removing automation can move more cooking, cleaning, and care onto women unless the community actively redistributes it. Restricting reproductive technology may limit bodily autonomy or the ways families can form. Adaptive tools can also determine whether someone is able to speak or move independently. An ethic of authorship becomes contradictory when leaders deny a person the means to author their own life. Access and consent must carry more weight than a purity test.

Environmental collapse and responsibility

The story does not establish that Caretaker caused ecological collapse. Its environmental question is whether either model of society can sustain its promises without exporting damage. A handmade object is not automatically more sustainable than an efficiently manufactured one. Grounded's gardens and

repair practices offer possibilities, while its water, energy, waste, and habitat records would make those claims testable. Ecological responsibility should reduce harm without turning poverty, illness, or forced primitivism into virtues.

State violence and surveillance

Caretaker has ended war; the story does not reveal a secret police force or hidden massacre. Its political danger is the concentration of power over perception. A system that alters what people encounter can prevent them from recognizing disagreement before any public debate begins. Grounded's elders reproduce a smaller version of that control through device inspection, confession, censorship, and threatened exclusion. The proposed code prohibits bodily punishment, forced confinement, and forced conversion as instruments of belief. Publishing decisions, limiting data collection, providing appeals, and protecting exit offer further constraints on coercive power. The daughter's painting tests whether those protections survive a challenge that could weaken the movement itself.

A voice that might undo us.

I built *The Grounded Movement* around a problem that a simple anti-technology story would avoid: what if the system works? *Caretaker* ends war, hunger, poverty, and preventable disease. Its citizens are genuinely happy. Maya does not expose a hidden atrocity. She discovers that a good life can still contain a missing relationship to making, choosing, and being understood. I wanted the movement's desire for agency to remain important without making its rejection of comfort automatically correct.

The unfinished painting gives that desire a physical form. Revisions are evidence of a person finding out what they mean. Maya's empty house then separates expression from satisfaction: the work can please its audience after *Caretaker* alters it, yet fail to communicate anything she intended. The First Witness reverses that process. People disagree, and one leaves. Their encounter matters because its outcome was not selected for them. The sacred act is attention with an uncertain result.

Octavia Butler's *Parable of the Talents* helps frame the tension between a liberating belief and the costs of building a movement around it. Lauren Olamina's *Earthseed* joins a philosophy of change to the practical work of forming community. The persecution of *Earthseed* also makes clear that a community's future depends on power beyond its own intentions. *Grounded* begins under different conditions: material security already exists. That difference lets me ask which freedoms remain important after immediate survival has been secured.

The novel's mother-daughter conflict is especially important to this project. Lauren's commitment to *Earthseed* and her daughter Asha's response to her journals do not resolve into a single heroic perspective. *Grounded* similarly refuses to let its founder supply the final interpretation of her child. Maya's daughter makes her own painting and still wants the life her mother rejected. Her work satisfies *Grounded*'s central rule while challenging its desired conclusion. If Maya protects only voices that agree with her, she has confused authorship with loyalty.

The project also draws a question from Afrofuturist traditions: who gets to imagine and build a future, and whose agency disappears inside someone else's progress? Butler makes speculative world-building inseparable from race, gender, belief, and power. I have used that challenge to examine my own fictional institutions. I am not claiming that *Grounded* represents Black experience or that adding a future setting makes any work Afrofuturist. The influence is an obligation to question the apparently universal human at the center of a technological promise.

Ken Gonzales-Day's account of Latinx Futurisms connects digital technology with queer Latinx self-representation, cultural heritage, and a claim to public space. That connection sharpens Maya's objection to Caretaker: a system cannot honor a maker while replacing the maker's history or difficult meaning with what an audience prefers. It also challenges elders who label one artistic tradition more authentic than another. Maya's surname alone cannot supply that cultural perspective; the influence lies in asking who controls representation.

Grace L. Dillon's writing on Indigenous Futurisms challenges futures that erase Indigenous presence or treat inhabited land as an empty frontier. It informs the proposed requirement that Grounded settlements reach agreements with existing communities before expanding. It also keeps the movement's land ethic from becoming a fantasy of abandoning technology: knowledge, science, and continuing relationships matter. These traditions are distinct, and this project does not claim to represent their communities or borrow their ceremonies.

I translated those concerns into institutional contradictions. Grounded's shared workshops can support independence, but tying access to good standing makes dissent costly. Its tool rule protects expression, but an absolute ban on adaptive technology can exclude the very person it promises to empower. Its labor ethic recognizes care, yet removing automation can reproduce unequal gender burdens. The proposed civic amendments identify possible repairs without claiming the elders have accepted them. The society remains accountable to effects, not just intentions.

The visual story uses an unfolding sequence and a final decision to make the reader encounter that contradiction before reading its explanation. The companion papers slow the experience down: a short poem can inspire, while a code reveals what inspiration must survive in practice. Neither final choice is a canonical ending. I do not argue that suffering produces better art, or that medicine and peace must be surrendered for meaning. I want the last question to remain uncomfortable: can a movement protect a voice whose freedom includes leaving it?

Literary and creative context

These sources ground the literary and cultural context. Connections to *Grounded* are the creator's interpretation.

- Octavia E. Butler, *Parable of the Talents* — publisher's synopsis of *Earthseed*, persecution, and Asha's perspective.
- Smithsonian, *Afrofuturism: A History of Black Futures* — Black identity, agency, freedom, and imagined futures.
- Ken Gonzales-Day, *Latinx Futurisms in Public Space* — an artist's account of queer Latinx representation, history, and technology.
- Grace L. Dillon, *Imagining Indigenous Futurisms* — Indigenous-centered futures, sovereignty, and relations between tradition and science.